

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

CFO-ORC FILE #

2001-117

2000-25

rec'd 12/9/01

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NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

Species: Red-necked Grebe (*Podiceps grisegena*)

Date: 1-2 December 2001

Number seen: one

Sex: ?

Plumage: Basic

Locality: Barr Lake

Elevation: about 5000'

Nearest town: Brighton

County: Adams

Time observed: ~15:00 - 15:10 MDT

Duration of observation: off and on for about 7 minutes during that time

Description: While scanning the birds on Barr Lake from the west end of the dam, Jason asked Joe and me what the smaller grebe was with the two Western Grebes by the dam. Joe and I looked at it and both realized that it was a Red-necked Grebe. We observed it for a short while and then walked east along the dam to get closer and a better view. The next morning, Chris and I went out along the dam to observe the bird and then later showed it to George. On both days, we initially found the bird within 10-20 meters of the dam, but on the morning of the 2nd, it then swam south to the middle of the lake, where it was when George saw it and when Doug and Rich saw it independently. I initially aged it as an adult, as the white cheek patch was without much smudging, but upon perusal of The Sibley Guide to Birds I noted that that author indicated first-basic plumage as having brighter cheek patches than in definitive basic.

It was a fairly large grebe, only somewhat smaller than the Western Grebes with it. It was overall fairly dark. The top half of the head was blackish and the auricular region was fairly bright white with little in the way of gray smudging. The neck was grayish, darker dorsally than ventrally with the very front of the throat whitish. The pointed bill, which was fairly thick (thicker than the Western Grebe bills) and relatively long (but shorter than the Western Grebe bills) for a grebe, was yellowish with a strongly dark culmen. The back was blackish, the sides were gray, and the chest was whitish. I did not see the belly or legs.

Similar species eliminated: There isn't particularly a species similar to Red-necked Grebe. Various diving ducks (e.g., Black Scoter and Red-breasted Merganser) are eliminated by the long, thin, dagger-like bill, the bill color, and the head pattern. All loons are easily eliminated by coloration and pattern.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen 10s of 1000s of Red-necked Grebes and 1000s of all other Colorado grebe species. I've also seen 100s to 10s of 1000s of all ducks that could be even remotely confused with Red-necked Grebe.

Light conditions: sun in front and to my left

Optical equipment used: Leica 32x and Swarovski 8.5x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest approach of about 90 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Jason Beason, Joe Fontaine, Chris Wood, George Wallace

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Doug Faulkner, Rich Levad

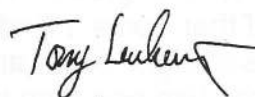
If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph; Chris did

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none **b) after observation:** none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 9 December 2001 from brief notes I wrote a few hours after the initial sighting